the country. With the regime dwindling in revenue and rigidly focused on the consolidation of its new vision of the Myanmar state and nation, few resources were dedicated to filling the gaping hole in 'soft' welfare provision.

The realization of the risks and brutal human costs of these crises prompted the regime to shift its policy towards non-governmental groups. Local military commanders began to negotiate with ostensibly 'non-political' community-based groups for delivery of much-needed social services (Callahan 2001, p. 41). As Myanmar transitioned from state-led socialism to a form of heavily licenced capitalism, petty traders and businessman were encouraged to take an active role in these social welfare groups and lead the provision of local 'public' goods such as roads that the state did not provide directly. In exchange they received public recognition as well as information from local military commanders about the latest project tenders or industry licences.[2] Community groups tending to the social needs of Burmese citizens blossomed as a result of this particular political economy and regime strategy. While overtly 'political' institutions continued to be harassed, one study found an estimated 214,000 community-based organizations (CBOs) operating in every corner of the country (Heidel 2006, p. 60).[3] These groups were forced to accept political domination in exchange for permission to pursue quotidian coping agendas focused on filling the social welfare gap left by the absence of the state and stagnant economy throughout much of the country.[4] While these groups were discursively constrained by the junta, they were permitted to engage in welfare activities and began to play a significant role in helping to mitigate health shocks, deliver basic education, and prevent dire poverty for millions of people.

This vital role was solidified further after the devastation wrought by Cyclone Nargis in 2008 and the inability of the regime to assist in providing immediate or long-term humanitarian assistance to those worst effected. While the regime remained preoccupied with military campaigns and the construction of 'hard infrastructure', religious organizations solidified and frequently significantly expanded their pre-existing role in welfare provision (Smith 2002, p. 26). Based on my ongoing fieldwork in central Myanmar, these welfare networks now form an essential part of the social infrastructure of everyday life in Taungoo and should be considered informal political institutions, the study of which is essential to obtain an understanding of contemporary Burmese political culture.